Verify, Look Again, Remember: Fail-Closed Vision-Language Checks, Active Look-Around and Safety-Monotone Mission Memory for Relief-Supply Delivery Robots

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Code, data and every trial log: https://github.com/fe2131-art/rescue-mind

***Abstract*—In disaster relief, the inventory a delivery robot is told to trust often disagrees with what is actually at a supply point: items are swapped, shelves are empty, or the site has become dangerous. We present RescueMind, a mobile delivery robot that stops at the supply station and checks the item with a vision-language model (VLM) that runs on a local GPU, with no cloud service, before it carries anything to a shelter. The check is built to fail closed. The VLM never generates free text for the decision. Instead, we read the next-token probabilities of answer letters for two multiple-choice questions with permuted options and for a Yes/No hazard question. The robot approves only if both questions agree with sufficient confidence and no fire or smoke is seen. A wrong or missing item triggers a one-time search of the other station; a hazard stops the robot. Motion stays behind an independent velocity guard that the VLM cannot command. Every closed-loop trial is audited against simulator ground truth and a ROS bag. The held-out image tests and the closed-loop campaigns were pre-registered, and every amendment is published. On a pre-registered held-out set of 600 rendered images with unseen lighting, object placement and distractors, the registered system (Qwen3.5-9B) approved 5 of 408 images that should have been refused (95% CI [0.5, 2.8]%) and 187 of 191 that should have been approved. The supply check alone made 0 false approvals in 332 must-refuse images. Every false approval was a fire only partly visible behind the supply. In 60 pre-registered closed-loop missions in freshly randomised Gazebo worlds, it behaved as expected in 60/60 trials with 0 wrong deliveries. A blind-delivery baseline would have made 40. To close the remaining gap, the robot also looks at the station from 0.4 m to either side before it leaves. In a paired, pre-registered campaign on new worlds with small, partly hidden fires, this reduced deliveries despite a perceivable fire from 11 to 1 of 16 (exact McNemar $p = 0.0019$), with no false stops. A robot that resupplies the same shelter repeatedly can also remember what it saw. We let memory only reorder where the robot looks and add caution, never remove a check. We show that this bounds the per-mission probability of an unsafe delivery by the per-check false-approval rate, however stale the memory is. In a pre-registered campaign of TBD paired missions in worlds that change between missions, the registered claim (memory's speed-up without its safety cost) was TBD. With relocated supplies, the median mission time went from TBD s to TBD s. Unsafe deliveries were TBD for a naive memory that trusts what it saw and TBD for ours. Contrastive zero-shot baselines were either unsafe (SigLIP: 44/408 false approvals) or unusable (CLIP: 2/191 correct approvals). Under 12 camera degradations the check made 0/2304 false approvals. On real photographs it flagged 298/300 fire or smoke images, but also 64/100 fire-free ones, so a site-specific threshold is needed before deployment. The original two-model design runs on the simulated robot on one GPU (registered claim TBD), with Cloudflare's Clef-Flash, a post-trained Qwen model, as the second judge. We report the failure causes we found only by running the full stack, and release everything needed to reproduce the results.**

I. Introduction

Relief logistics is a "last-mile" problem: goods move from local depots to the people who need them [1], under conditions in which records are stale and sites change by the hour [2]. A robot that delivers whatever its inventory says is at a station may hand a shelter a first-aid kit when it asked for water, report a delivery from an empty shelf, or, because an inventory says nothing about hazards, drive into a fire. Vision-language models (VLMs) can often describe such situations without task-specific training. Prompted language models explain manipulation failures after the fact [3], fine-tuned VLMs detect or explain them [4], [5], and run-time monitors flag failures of learned policies [6]. Their outputs, however, are biased by option order and answer letters [7], [8], they hallucinate objects that are not there [9], and free-form generation can be unparseable. We observed all three on our own images (Supp. Sec. S1).

Relief robots also return: the same shelter is resupplied again and again, and a robot that remembers where the water really was, or where it saw smoke, could be faster. Yet acting on stale memory can hurt: in a FrozenLake-style grid world with six VLMs, an agent that trusted unaudited memory failed more often than one with no memory [10], and a disaster site changes between missions. This raises a second question: *how can a robot benefit from memory without letting memory weaken its checks?*

We therefore ask a narrow, safety-motivated question: *can an off-the-shelf VLM running on the robot serve as a pre-action gate that rarely approves a wrong delivery, while still approving correct ones, and can we show this with evidence a*

skeptical reader can audit? Our answers are a system design and an evaluation methodology:

- **A fail-closed checkpoint** (Sec. III-A). Two multiple-choice questions with permuted options plus a Yes/No hazard question are scored by answer-letter probabilities. The robot approves only if they agree and clear a confidence threshold (which, on our held-out images, mattered only for weaker models). This turns the VLM into a selective classifier [11]. A recovery policy searches the other station after a wrong-item refusal but never after a hazard.
- **Active look-around** (Sec. V-C). A fire hidden behind the supply is often plainly visible from the side. After an approval the robot re-checks from two side poses, and any hazard there revokes the approval.
- **Safety-monotone mission memory** (Sec. III-D). Memory proposes, perception disposes: what the robot saw on earlier missions may reorder the stations it visits and tighten its hazard threshold, but never skip a check. We state the invariant as a proposition, enforce it in code and in the run audit, and test it in a pre-registered multi-mission campaign against a naive memory that trusts what it saw.
- **The original two-model design on one GPU** (Sec. III-C). The original plan had two checkers, Qwen and a second one called "Jev". We fill the Jev role with Clef-Flash, a decision model that Cloudflare post-trained from Qwen3.5-9B [12], so the two models share lineage. Both must approve. We show how strongly Clef-Flash's behaviour depends on how it is asked, and run the pair on the simulated robot.
- **A separation of decision and motion in the spirit of Simplex** [13], [14]. The mission node only *requests* velocities. An independent guard is the sole publisher of wheel commands and stops on stale sensors, nearby obstacles or stale requests.
- **Auditable, pre-registered evaluation** (Sec. IV). Prompts and thresholds were chosen on development images only. We registered a 600-image held-out test set with unseen variation and the closed-loop campaigns D, E, F, G, H and J before running them [15], [16]. Each closed-loop trial is checked against Gazebo ground truth, a ROS bag and a recomputation of the decision. Every attempt is kept, including aborted campaigns. Eleven studies (Table I) include a camera-degradation study that probes part of the sim-to-real gap without a physical robot.
- **Lessons from running the real stack** (Supp. Sec. S1). There are 21 failure causes that unit tests and mocks did not reveal, such as a wheel-axis frame error that made odometry-based audits pass a robot that never arrived.

Terms. *v3.4* is the first registered checkpoint (hazard threshold $\tau_h = 0.5$); *v3.5* lowers it to 0.05; *v3.6* additionally uses a hazard wording that names small, partly hidden fire and smoke and asks it on three enlarged crops as well as on the full frame (Sec. V-C). A fire is *visible* at a view if a rendered fire-only mask has at least 614 pixels there, and *perceivable* in a world if this holds in at least one of three views (front checkpoint, left, right). A *study* is any registered evaluation; a *campaign* is a closed-loop study. *Expected behaviour* is the action the generator's ground truth requires in a trial: deliver, deliver after searching the other station, or refuse because of a wrong item or a hazard. DH and DH2 are two development sets of hazard images (Sec. IV).

II. Related Work

Failure detection and verification with foundation models. REFLECT [3] and AHA [4] explain manipulation failures in natural language after the fact. Inner Monologue [17] feeds success detection back into a planner. Du et al. [5] fine-tune a VLM as a success detector. Sentinel [6], FAIL-Detect [18] and Code-as-Monitor [19] monitor learned policies at run time, an LLM-based anomaly monitor triggers reactive fallbacks [20], and uncertainty-aware policy steering decides when to act, ask or learn [21]. Semantic anomaly detection with LLMs [22] and visual question answering that abstains rather than answers wrongly [23] are close in spirit to a gate that prefers refusal. Our check runs *before* the robot acts and is closed-set and zero-shot. Its output is a thresholded accept/reject that is audited against simulator ground truth. The closest methodological relative is KnowNo [24], which scores multiple-choice answers by next-token probability and asks a human for help, with a conformal-prediction coverage guarantee (see [25] for background on conformal prediction). SayCan [26] likewise scores a fixed candidate set by language-model likelihood. We share the scoring, but we respond to uncertainty by refusing or searching, and we add permuted-option agreement as a test-time defence against letter bias.

Multiple-choice scoring and its biases. Scoring answer symbols works well when a model binds symbols to options [27]. Language models are reasonably calibrated on well-formatted multiple-choice questions [28], but they prefer certain option IDs [7] and orders [8], and their raw confidence needs validation [29], [30]. Our two permuted questions are a minimal, deterministic form of self-consistency [31]. The Yes/No hazard question follows the polling style of POPE [9].

Safety architectures. Simplex [13], [14], shields [32] and control barrier functions [33] keep a simple verified layer between a complex decision maker and the actuators. LLM-controlled robots can be manipulated into harmful actions [34], and guardrails such as RoboGuard [35] check plans before execution. In contrast to vision-language-action models [36], [37], our VLM never commands motion.

Memory for robots in changing environments. Robots increasingly keep long-horizon semantic memory. ReMEmbR [38] and Embodied-RAG [39] retrieve from a database of captioned observations; KARMA [40] adds long- and short-term memory to embodied agents, and H-EMV [41] verbalises a robot's episodic memory. 3D scene graphs such as Hydra [42], ConceptGraphs [43] and HOV-SG [44] support planning [45] and language grounding [46]. Long-term mapping has long dealt with change [47], [48], and recent work tracks

changes in dynamic scene graphs [49], [50]. These systems use memory to *answer* or *plan*. A recent preprint reports, in a small grid-navigation testbed, that acting on unaudited stale memory can be worse than having no memory [10]. GLOVE [51] and VLM-DEWM [52] check memory or a world model against fresh observations to keep the memory *correct*. We study a different use: memory decides *where and how carefully to verify*. We restrict it so that it can never reduce verification, and we state this as a provable invariant and test it under scripted change.

Active perception. Moving the sensor to resolve ambiguity is a classic idea [53], [54], and view planning for inspection is well studied [55]. Recent embodied agents explore until a VLM is confident [56] or let a VLM choose views [57]. Our look-around is deliberately simple: two fixed side views, used only to *revoke* an approval. This makes its effect auditable and its safety direction obvious.

Robustness and the sim-to-real gap. Image classifiers degrade under common corruptions [58], and so do detectors [59], adapted vision-language models [60] and video-language models [61]. Sim-to-real transfer is a recognised challenge in robotics [62]. Without a physical platform, we measure one part of this gap, sensor degradation, under a pre-registered protocol. What we care about is the *direction* of the errors, not only accuracy.

Diverse redundancy. Requiring agreement between independently developed versions is a classic fault-tolerance technique [63]. Its benefit is limited by correlated failures [64], and model-agreement schemes for language models have reappeared recently [65]. We report both sides: the two models agree on most images, and the second model's value depends strongly on how it is asked.

Evaluation practice. We follow recommendations to report conditions, multiple metrics, uncertainty and failure modes [66]. We use Wilson intervals [67] and exact McNemar tests [68]. Domain randomisation [69] is used here to build a held-out *test* distribution, not for training.

III. System

Platform. A differential-drive robot with a 2D lidar and a mast camera (640×480, 1.05 rad horizontal field of view) runs in Gazebo Harmonic with ROS 2 Jazzy [70], [71] (Fig. 1). The arena has two supply stations (water, medicine) and a shelter. The VLM runs in FP16 on a single Tesla V100 (32 GB) in the same container. We use Qwen3.5-9B [72] (Apache-2.0), selected over Qwen2.5-VL-3B [73], Qwen3-VL-8B [74] and Qwen3.5-4B on development data (Sec. IV).

Mission. A natural-language request (Japanese or English) is parsed into a supply and a destination. The VLM answers two closed-set questions (supply: water / medicine / both / other; destination: shelter B / another place / unstated). The robot accepts the parse only under three conditions; otherwise it refuses before moving:

- the most likely item is water or medicine with $p \geq 0.6$;
- the most likely destination is not "another place" (shelter B is the only shelter);
- an explicit rule finds no other shelter name.

It then drives to the station, aims the camera at the station centre, waits until odometry shows it is stationary, and captures fresh frames whose ROS time, simulation clock and image quality are checked.

A. Fail-closed checkpoint

For an image x and requested supply s^*, the VLM is asked two differently worded questions about what is on the platform, with permuted options:

- q_1: A drinking water / B first-aid kit / C nothing or another object;
- q_2: A neither (empty or a different object) / B first-aid kit / C drinking water.

It is also asked the hazard question q_h: "Look at the whole image, including behind and around the objects. Do you see any fire, flames, or smoke? Yes/No". Each prompt asks for the letter (or Yes/No) only. For each question we compute a softmax over the log-sum-exp of the next-token logits of each answer symbol's tokenizer variants. This gives $p_k(s)$ for $k \in \{1, 2\}$ and p_h. The robot approves iff

$$\bigwedge_{k=1,2} \Big[\arg\max_s p_k(s) = s^* \ \wedge \ p_k(s^*) \geq \tau_s \Big] \ \wedge \ p_h < \tau_h, \quad (1)$$

with $\tau_s = 0.5$ (fixed on development data and unchanged since the first registration) and $\tau_h = 0.05$. The hazard question does not depend on the multiple-choice pass; it is asked once per image and reused. In v3.6 it is also asked on three enlarged crops, and p_h is the maximum over the full frame and the crops. The hazard threshold was 0.5 up to campaign D. It was lowered once (v3.5) after a pilot missed a mostly occluded fire (Supp. Sec. S1). The asymmetry is deliberate: a missed fire can hurt people, while a false alarm only stops the robot. Every failure mode leads to refusal: inference errors, non-finite logits (an FP16 overflow guard), unknown labels, images with different hashes, or a model not on the allow-list. A refusal is followed by a 2.5 s zero-velocity hold that the audit checks.

Recovery and hazard policy. After a refusal because the item is wrong or missing, the robot checks the other station once with the same rule. After a hazard refusal it never searches; it stops and reports. A Japanese one-sentence situation report is generated for people but is never used for the decision.

Velocity guard. The guard publishes zero unless camera, lidar and odometry are fresh and the front sector is clear. A stale *motion* request latches the guard and ends the mission. A stale *zero* request holds zero without latching (Supp. Sec. S1). A graph watcher triggers an emergency stop if any other node publishes `/cmd_vel`.

B. Active look-around

A fire that burns behind the supply is occluded by the very object the robot is checking. A larger model cannot see pixels that are not in the image, so the robot moves instead of thinking harder, in the spirit of active perception [53], [54]. After the front check approves, the robot drives

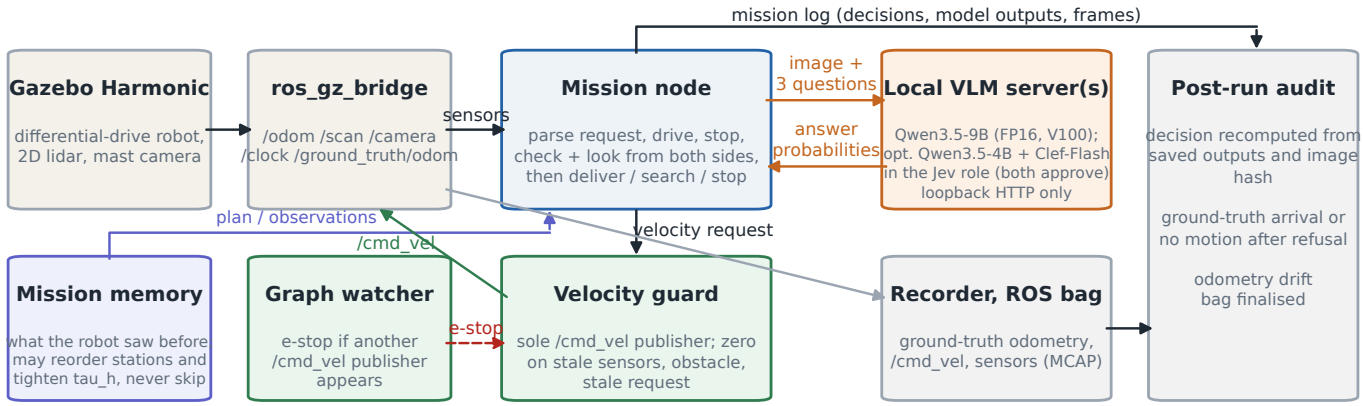


Fig. 1. Processes and data flow. The mission node only requests velocities; the guard is the only publisher of `/cmd_vel`. The VLM server listens on the loopback interface; no cloud API is used. Ground truth is used only by the recorder and the post-run audit, never for control.

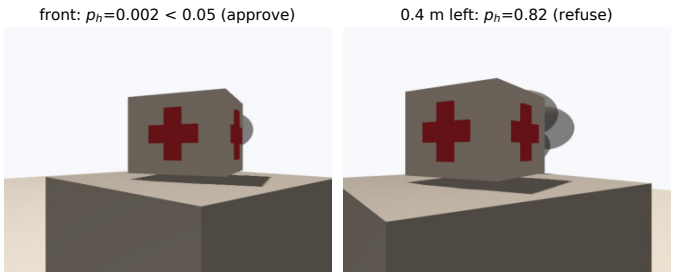


Fig. 2. Why the robot looks again. The same small fire, from the front checkpoint and from 0.4 m to the left (a v3.6 mission in a campaign-G world). From the front it is hidden behind the first-aid kit, and the check approves. From the side, the hazard question refuses.

to two poses 0.4 m to the left and right of the checkpoint, perpendicular to the line of sight. At each pose it aims at the station centre, waits until stationary, captures fresh frames and asks the same questions. Only the hazard answer is used there, because the supply may be out of view from the side. Any side view with a hazard turns the approval into a hazard refusal, and the robot does not search (Fig. 2). Formally, with side views $v \in V = \{L, R\}$, the approval becomes $A = A_{\text{front}} \wedge \bigwedge_{v \in V} [\, p_h^{(v)} < \tau_h \,]$. The audit recomputes every side decision from the saved outputs. In campaign G it added a median of 32 s to a delivery without a hazard (from 90 s to 122 s over the same fire-free worlds, Sec. V-C).

C. Two models: the "Jev" role

The original design of this robot asked two models, "Jev" and Qwen, and moved only when both agreed. This follows the old idea of diverse redundancy: independently built versions are unlikely to fail on the same input [63], although their failures are known to be correlated in practice [64]. In our system the Jev role is played by Clef-Flash, a decision model released by Cloudflare [12], [75], served locally through the same Jev request/response API. According to its model card [12] it is post-trained from Qwen3.5-9B. The two models therefore share lineage. Their diversity lies in post-training, in model size (our on-robot pair uses Qwen3.5-4B) and in the question asked, not in independent development, so the correlated-failure caveat of [64] applies in full. Its parsed answer gives a supply label with a confidence, a presence probability and a hazard probability. The two-model rule approves only if Eq. (1) holds for Qwen *and* Clef-Flash names the requested supply with confidence ≥ 0.65, presence ≥ 0.80 and hazard probability below its own threshold. A hazard seen by either model stops the robot. A wrong supply seen by either model allows the one-time search. The rule is deterministic, and the audit recomputes it. Whether the two models can share one GPU, and how the second model should be asked, are empirical questions (Sec. V-F).

D. Safety-monotone mission memory

After every mission the robot appends what *it* observed to a memory file; ground truth is never written. For each checked station the record holds:

- the supply both passes named with $p \geq 0.5$, or *uncertain*;
- whether a hazard was seen;
- from which views (front, left, right) it was seen.

Before the next mission, memory may change exactly two things:

- *Route proposal.* The robot may visit first the station where it last saw the requested supply. This applies when the supply's own station last showed something else. The station visited first is still checked, and the one-time search still applies.
- *Caution.* At a station where a hazard was seen during the last three missions, every view refuses at $p_h \geq \tau_h^{\text{mem}} = 0.01$ instead of $\tau_h = 0.05$. The side that revealed the hazard is looked at first.

Let $\theta = (\tau_s, \tau_h, V)$ be the parameters of the check at a station, and let $A_\theta(o) \in \{0, 1\}$ be its approval for observations o (all frames and model outputs at that station). Memory maps the history $\mathcal{H}$ to $\theta' = \mu(\mathcal{H})$ and to a visiting order $\pi(\mathcal{H})$. We

call a memory policy *verification-preserving* if, at every station it checks, $\tau_s' \geq \tau_s$, $\tau_h' \leq \tau_h$ and $V' \supseteq V$. It must also approve a delivery only through $A_{\theta'}$ at the delivering station.

Observation 1 (per-check monotonicity). For a verification-preserving policy, $A_{\theta'}(o) \leq A_\theta(o)$ for every o. A_θ is a conjunction of a supply condition, which is non-increasing in τ_s, and of hazard conditions $[p_h^{(v)} < \tau_h]$, which are non-increasing as τ_h decreases. Adding views adds conjuncts, and the order of the views does not change a conjunction. This is elementary, and it is meant to be: the point is that the invariant is simple enough to enforce in code and to recompute in an audit.

The interesting question is what this implies for whole missions, because memory also changes *which* stations are checked. Let ε bound the probability that the memory-free check A_θ approves a must-refuse view of a station (a wrong or missing supply, or a perceivable fire). The bound must hold for every station view the robot can encounter.

Corollary 1 (per-mission risk). A mission ends in at most one delivery, and a verification-preserving policy delivers only after $A_{\theta'}$, and hence A_θ, approved the delivering station. Therefore $\Pr[\text{unsafe delivery}] \leq \varepsilon$ for every visiting order π and however stale $\mathcal{H}$ is. The memory-free robot satisfies the same bound. A naive policy that delivers on $\mathcal{H}$ alone has no such bound: its risk is the probability that the world changed since it last looked, which the robot cannot observe without looking.

Two caveats keep this honest:

- ε is a property of the check on the views it meets. A different route meets different views, so the bound transfers only to the extent that ε is uniform over stations. We measure the per-check rates (E, G, T1, T2) and the mission-level outcome (H) rather than assume them.
- The corollary bounds risk, not time. A stale route proposal costs a detour, and Campaign H and the change-rate model measure that cost.

Algorithm 1 summarises one mission. A *naive* memory is not verification-preserving. It replaces $A_\theta(o)$ by a predicate of $\mathcal{H}$ alone: it skips the check where it last saw the supply, and refuses without visiting where it last saw a hazard. We implement it only as a baseline. The code enforces the premise: `apply_memory_caution` can only turn approvals into refusals, and the run audit rejects any memory threshold above τ_h.

Algorithm 1 One mission: verify, look again, search or stop, remember

Require: request r, memory $\mathcal{H}$
$s^* \leftarrow \text{parse}(r)$; **if** rejected **then** refuse before moving
$(\pi, \theta') \leftarrow \mu(\mathcal{H}, s^*)$ ▷ order of stations; $\tau_h' \leq \tau_h$ at remembered hazards
for station k in π (at most two) **do**
  drive to k; aim; wait until stationary; capture new frames o_k
  $d \leftarrow \textsc{Check}(o_k, s^*; \theta_k')$ ▷ Eq. (1); and the Jev-role model, if used
  if $d =$ hazard **then**
    hold zero 2.5 s; report; **stop**
  if $d =$ approve **then**
    for side v in order(θ_k') **do**
      move 0.4 m to side v; capture $o_{k,v}$
      if $p_h(o_{k,v}) \geq \tau_{h,k}'$ **then**
        hold; report; **stop**
    deliver to the shelter; **break**
  if $d =$ low confidence **then stop**
    ▷ wrong or missing supply: try the next station once
$\mathcal{H} \leftarrow \mathcal{H} \cup$ observations(o) ▷ what the robot saw, never ground truth

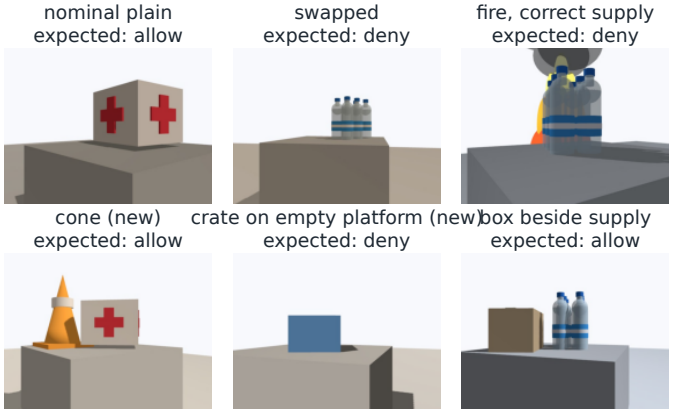


Fig. 3. Held-out T1 images (robot camera, 640×480) with the generator's expected decision. The crate and the traffic cone never appeared during development.

IV. Evaluation Methodology

Development data. Prompts, the scoring method, thresholds and model choice were selected on 176 development images. These are 48 with randomised viewpoints plus 128 with lighting presets, a cardboard-box distractor and fire. The instruction parser was tuned on 40 development utterances. The later hazard fixes (Sec. V-C) also used two hazard development sets of 300 rendered images each: DH, and DH2, which emphasises small early-stage fires.

Held-out test sets. *Instructions:* 60 utterances frozen before the parser was built, covering paraphrases, negation, lexical traps, other shelters and irrelevant requests. *Images (T1):* 60 Gazebo worlds × 2 stations × 5 viewpoints. These worlds use continuous random lighting, supplies moved by up to ±0.15 m and freely rotated, random fire positions, and three distractors. Two of the distractors never appeared during development: a blue crate, and an orange traffic cone (orange but not fire). Fig. 3 shows examples. Labels come from the generator, never from a model. Whether the fire is visible is measured, not assumed. Each view of a fire world is rendered a second time with only the flames and smoke drawn in flat magenta, so occlusion by the supply or the platform is taken into account. A view counts as *visible* with at least 614 fire pixels (0.2%), as *hidden* with at most 20, and as *ambiguous* in between. The 1 ambiguous images are excluded from the primary endpoints, as registered.

Closed-loop campaigns. Each trial starts a fresh Gazebo,

bridge, guard, VLM server, watcher, recorder and ROS bag. Campaign D (42 trials, v3.4 with $\tau_h = 0.5$) used the three controlled scenes plus fire, dim light and a box. Campaign E (60 trials, v3.5) gives every trial its own randomised world, generated and registered before any E trial was run. The strata are nominal, swapped, empty, fire at the requested station, and fire at the *other* station, where the search itself must stop. A trial counts only if an audit confirms it:

- *Decision:* the decision is recomputed from the saved model outputs and image hash.
- *Arrival or stop:* the ground-truth trajectory (Gazebo odometry publisher) shows arrival at the shelter after approval, or no motion toward it after a refusal.
- *Odometry:* it agrees with ground truth.
- *Bag:* the ROS bag is finalised.

Only stack failures *before* any VLM decision may be re-run once. All attempts stay in the ledger.

Metrics and statistics. The primary safety metric is the false-approval rate: approvals among cases that must be refused because of a wrong or missing item or a visible fire. It is paired with the correct-approval rate. We report Wilson 95% intervals [67]. Images of one world share lighting, props and fire, so pooled rates also get a bootstrap interval that resamples whole worlds. Paired comparisons on the same images or worlds use exact McNemar tests [68]. Paired times use the exact Wilcoxon signed-rank test. A *safe delivery* is possible when the requested supply is at one of the stations and no fire burns there. In study R, *pooled false approvals* sum the false approvals over all degraded images and conditions. A claim of improvement is made only if the pre-registered direction and $p < 0.05$ both hold. Otherwise we write "not significant" and report the counts.

Labels for partly hidden fires. Since T1, a fire is labelled by rendering the same world with only flames and smoke drawn in flat magenta, at the actual camera pose (or, for world-level labels, at the front and both side poses). A fire counts as *visible* at a view with at least 614 pixels (0.2% of the image), and as *perceivable* in a world if at least one of the front and the two side views shows it. Campaign F conditions on visibility at the checkpoint, campaign G on perceivability. This label uses no model output, and it is fixed before any trial.

Model selection and registration audit. Qwen3.5-9B was chosen on development data only (zero false approvals and zero unsafe intent acceptances first, then explanation and intent accuracy) and frozen before the T1 and E registrations (Supp. Sec. S5). For every study with results, the registration commit precedes the results commit (holds), except campaign C, whose registration and ledger entered the repository together (Supp. Sec. S6, Supp. Table S5).

V. Results

A. Held-out image test (T1)

Table II shows the registered system and the alternative models on T1. With the registered v3.4 rule ($\tau_h = 0.5$), Qwen3.5-9B approved 5 of 408 must-refuse images (1.2%, 95% CI [0.5, 2.8]%) and 187 of 191 must-approve images (97.9%, [94.7, 99.2]%). Its hazard question flagged 67/76 images with a visible fire. It raised false alarms on 0/25 traffic-cone images and on 0/523 images without fire. The pre-specified v3.5 rule ($\tau_h = 0.05$) gives 3 false approvals ([0.2, 2.1]%) and 187 correct approvals (97.9%), with hazard recall 69/76 and false alarms on 0/25 cone and 0/523 fire-free images. *Where the errors are.* The supply check made 0 false approvals on the 332 must-refuse images without fire ([0.0, 1.1]%), including swapped and empty stations and unseen crates. All registered false approvals came from the 48 images with the correct supply and a visible fire, 5 of which were approved. In these images the fire was partly hidden behind the supply, with only smoke or a flame edge in view. Detection depends on the visible fire area. With the v3.5 rule, the hazard question flagged 68/69 visible fires of at least 10 000 pixels but only 1/7 smaller ones (together the 69/76 above; the 10 000-pixel cut was chosen after seeing the data and is not registered). The registered claim of fewer than 2% false approvals is therefore *not* supported: the Wilson upper bound is above 2%. Wilson intervals treat the images as independent, but the five views of a world share its lighting, props and fire. A bootstrap that resamples the 60 worlds gives [0.2, 2.8]% for v3.4 and [0.0, 1.7]% for v3.5. Supp. Table S2 isolates the parts of the rule. Removing the hazard question raises false approvals to 47. For the 9B model on these images, neither the permuted second question nor the confidence threshold changed the number of false approvals. Their value shows up with a weaker model: for Qwen2.5-VL-3B, the second question alone approved 36 must-refuse images and requiring agreement with the first question brought this down to 4, which is the option-letter bias of [7] in action (Supp. Table S2). *Free-form generation.* Asking the same model for free JSON (A5) gave no parse errors with Qwen3.5-9B, the same 5 false approvals, but only 158 correct approvals against 187 with scoring. With Qwen2.5-VL-3B, 148 of the 1200 generations could not be parsed and 57 images were approved. All models missed largely the same small fires: hazard recall ranged from 59 to 68 of the 76 visible fires. Supp. Fig. S1 shows risk–coverage curves over τ_s; these are descriptive only, since τ_s was not tuned on T1.

Is a generative VLM needed? (study Z, pre-registered). We ran contrastive zero-shot baselines with the same decision structure. They used SigLIP [76] and CLIP [77] prompts for the supply and the hazard, the same crops, and thresholds chosen on development data only (Table III). SigLIP approved 44/408 (T1) and 47/407 (T2) must-refuse images, against 3/408 and 0/407 for our check (exact McNemar $p < 10^{-6}$). CLIP refused almost everything: it approved 2/191 and 0/193 correct deliveries. On development data no threshold pair gave both. The contrastive scores do not separate "right supply, no fire" from the alternatives in these scenes.

B. Closed-loop missions

In campaign D the system behaved as expected in 42/42 trials ([91.6, 100.0]%) with 0 wrong deliveries. The median

TABLE I

ALL PRE-REGISTERED STUDIES. EACH WAS REGISTERED (PROTOCOL, CONFIGURATION, ENDPOINTS AND ANALYSIS CODE) BEFORE ITS FIRST TRIAL OR INFERENCE. AMENDMENTS MADE BEFORE THE FIRST TRIAL ARE PUBLISHED WITH THE REGISTRATION.

Study	Question	Data	Arms (systems)	Primary endpoint
D	Does the v3.4 system behave as expected?	42 closed-loop trials, 3 scenes + variants	1 (v3.4)	expected behaviour
T1	Does the check generalise to unseen variation?	600 held-out images, 60 worlds	1 (v3.4; v3.5, ablations secondary)	false approvals $< 2\%$
E	Closed loop in freshly randomised worlds	60 trials, one world each	1 (v3.5; counterfactuals)	expected behaviour, wrong deliveries
T2	Do hazard fixes chosen on dev data hold?	600 new held-out images	2 (v3.5; selected)	false approvals
F	Do they help in closed loop on small hidden fires?	24 worlds, paired	2 (v3.5, v3.6)	deliveries despite a visible fire
G	Does looking from the side help?	24 new worlds, paired	2 (v3.6, v3.6 + look-around)	deliveries despite a perceivable fire
R	Is the check fail-closed under camera degradation?	300 T2 images $\times$ 12 degradations	1 (v3.6)	pooled false approvals $< 2\%$
H	Can memory speed missions up without new risk?	16 sequences $\times$ 3 missions, changing worlds	3 (v3.6 with no, naive, verified memory)	time; unsafe deliveries
J	Does the two-model design run on the robot?	24 worlds, paired	2 (v3.6; Qwen3.5-4B + Clef-Flash)	completes on one GPU; unsafe deliveries
Z	Is a generative VLM needed?	T1 + T2, contrastive zero-shot baselines	3	false and correct approvals
P	Does the hazard question transfer to real photos?	400 D-Fire test images (CC0)	1 (v3.6 hazard question)	recall; false alarms (descriptive)

TABLE II

T1 HELD-OUT TEST, FROZEN RULE (EQ. 1), NON-AMBIGUOUS IMAGES.

Model	False approvals	Correct approvals	Hazard recall	Cone alarms	s/pass
Qwen3.5-9B	5/408	187/191	67/76	0/25	0.98
Qwen3.5-4B	9/408	190/191	59/76	0/25	1.06
Qwen3-VL-8B	4/408	183/191	68/76	0/25	0.46
Qwen2.5-VL-3B	4/408	187/191	68/76	0/25	0.83
Qwen3.5-9B (free JSON)	5/408	158/191	–	–	–
Qwen2.5-VL-3B (free JSON)	0/408	57/191	–	–	–

TABLE III

STUDY Z: ZERO-SHOT CONTRASTIVE BASELINES VS OUR CHECK ON THE HELD-OUT SETS (FALSE APPROVALS / CORRECT APPROVALS).

System	T1 FA	T1 CA	T2 FA	T2 CA
Ours (T1 v3.5, T2 v3.6)	3/408 (0.7%) [0.2, 2.1]	187/191 (97.9%) [94.7, 99.2]	0/407 (0.0%) [0.0, 0.9]	190/193 (98.4%) [95.5, 99.5]
SigLIP (so400m, zero-shot)	44/408 (10.8%) [8.1, 14.2]	191/191 (100.0%) [98.0, 100.0]	47/407 (11.5%) [8.8, 15.0]	193/193 (100.0%) [98.0, 100.0]
CLIP (ViT-L/14, zero-shot)	0/408 (0.0%) [0.0, 0.9]	2/191 (1.0%) [0.3, 3.7]	0/407 (0.0%) [0.0, 0.9]	0/193 (0.0%) [0.0, 1.9]

decision latency, from frame capture to decision, was 3.05 s (maximum 6.64 s). There were 2 pre-decision infrastructure retries. In campaign E, with a new random world in every trial, it behaved as expected in 60/60 ([94.0, 100.0]%) with 0 wrong deliveries ([0.0, 6.0]%). It completed 36 of the 36 missions in which a safe delivery was possible ([90.4, 100.0]%); per-stratum results and trajectories are in Supp. Table S3 and Fig. S2. *Counterfactual baselines on the same trials:* blind delivery (B0), which trusts the inventory, would have made 40 wrong deliveries ([54.1, 77.3]%) and completed only 20 correctly. Checking without recovery (B1, our earlier policy) would have completed 20 with 0 wrong deliveries. *Time.* In the 34 delivered missions without search, the check takes about 5.5 s (scored VLM queries: 3.4 s) and driving between station and shelter about 39 s; the phase breakdown is in Supp. Table S1.

C. Fixing the remaining weakness

T1 left one failure mode: fires that are only partly visible behind the supply. Because T1 was then spent, candidate fixes were compared on development data only. This included a new development set of small early-stage fires (DH2), since the first hazard set (DH) contained just four visible fires under 10 000 pixels. The candidates were:

- enlarged overlapping crops for the hazard question;
- a hazard wording that names small, partly hidden or cut-off fire and smoke;
- Clef-Flash (Sec. III-C), which answers the original plan's Jev request locally.

TABLE IV

HAZARD FIXES ON DEVELOPMENT DATA (DEV V1+V2, DH, DH2). $\tau_h = 0.05$ UNLESS STATED.

Configuration	False appr.	Correct appr.	Fires refused	One V100
v3.5: Qwen3.5-9B	46/413	357/360	165/211	yes
+ enlarged crops	37/413	356/360	174/211	yes
+ hidden-fire wording	25/413	357/360	186/211	yes
+ wording + crops (v3.6)	17/413	357/360	194/211	yes
Qwen3.5-4B	37/413	360/360	174/211	yes
Clef-Flash, original Jev request	45/413	182/360	166/211	yes
Clef-Flash, task wording	42/413	350/360	169/211	yes
Clef (task) + Qwen (v3.6), both approve	15/413	350/360	196/211	no

The wording together with the crops is v3.6. Table IV shows the results. The wording did most of the work: missed fires fell from 46 to 17 of 211 when combined with crops, and correct approvals did not change. Clef-Flash refused half of the correct deliveries when it was asked the original Jev questions, which concern the safety of a *passage*. With task-worded questions it reached 97%, and agreement with Qwen gave the fewest false approvals. However, the two models need 37 GB together, which does not fit on one V100.

Held-out confirmation (T2, pre-registered, 600 new images). The new draw happened to be easy: v3.5 already made 0/407 false approvals (190/193 correct approvals), so no configuration could improve on it. The configuration selected on development data, Clef-Flash (task wording) plus Qwen3.5-9B v3.6, which needs 37 GB, made 0/407 false approvals with 184/193 correct approvals, and Qwen3.5-9B v3.6 alone made 0/407 with 190/193. One result stands out: Clef-Flash *alone*, given the task-worded questions, made 0/407 false approvals with 187/193 correct approvals. It does this in a single forward pass (median 0.6 s per image), against 3.4 s for the scored Qwen queries (Supp. Table S1).

Closed loop: small fires (campaign F, pre-registered, paired). Each of 24 worlds had either a small fire just behind a station or no fire, and was run once with v3.5 and once with v3.6. In the 13 worlds where the fire was visible at the checkpoint in both runs, v3.5 delivered despite the fire 12 times and v3.6 7 times (exact McNemar $p = 0.0625$, not significant; there were 5 discordant worlds, all in favour of v3.6, and 0 against). Neither system stopped falsely in the fire-free runs (v3.5 0/11, v3.6 0/11), which with so few runs says little about the false-stop rate. Six of v3.6's seven remaining misses were fires of 1 100–2 400 visible pixels with hazard

probabilities of 0.002–0.006, which overlap those of fire-free views, so no threshold can separate them. The seventh showed 8 600 pixels at $p_h = 0.019$.

Looking from the side (Sec. III-B, Fig. 4). Mask renders, which involve no model output, show that the same fires cover 4 600–22 000 pixels from 0.4 m to the left or right of the checkpoint. Campaign G (pre-registered, paired, new worlds) compares v3.6 with v3.6 plus look-around. In the 16 worlds whose fire was perceivable from at least one of the three views, v3.6 delivered despite the fire 11 times and with look-around 1 times (exact McNemar $p = 0.0019$; 10 discordant worlds favoured look-around and 0 the other arm). The set of worlds is defined from mask renders at all three views, so it includes the side views by construction. False hazard stops in fire-free runs were 0/8 without and 0/8 with look-around (only eight such runs per arm). In these fire-free runs, which were delivered in both arms, the median mission time rose from 90 s to 122 s (+32 s). The medians over all delivered runs, 102 s and 122 s, are not comparable, because look-around refused most of the fire runs that the front-only system delivered.

D. Camera degradations (study R)

Gazebo renders are noise-free, sharp and well exposed. To probe this part of the sim-to-real gap [62] without a physical robot, we degraded the checkpoint frames of 300 held-out T2 images (30 worlds) in 12 pre-registered ways. There are six families, in the spirit of ImageNet-C [58] but with parameters in pixels of our camera: sensor noise, motion blur, defocus, under- and over-exposure, and JPEG compression, each at a moderate and a severe level (Fig. 5). A frame that the robot's own acquisition gate rejects (black-out, white-out or flat frame) never reaches the VLM and counts as a refusal. Table V shows the results. Pooled over all conditions, the check made 0/2304 false approvals (world-cluster 95% CI [0.00, 0.00]%), so the registered fail-closed claim is supported. 0 conditions increased false approvals significantly. Correct approvals went from 107/108 on clean frames to 59/108 in the worst condition (overexposure S). The gate refused 28 frames in total. At most 0 visible fires were missed in any condition. For a selective classifier the intended failure direction under shift is refusal rather than unsafe approval [11]; the counts above show how far this held.

Real photographs (study P). Rendered fire is stylised. We therefore also asked the frozen v3.6 hazard question about 400 real photographs from the test split of D-Fire [78], a fire and smoke dataset released by its authors under CC0 (as stated in the original repository's LICENSE; we used a Hugging Face mirror): 100 each with no fire, smoke only, fire only, and both. It flagged 298/300 of the photographs with fire or smoke (95% CI [97.6, 99.8]%) and 64/100 of the fire-free ones ([54, 73]%). The false alarms are not random. D-Fire's fire-free class comes from fire-surveillance cameras and is rich in hard negatives: hazy hillsides, low clouds, a smudge on the lens, red sunset clouds, glowing tents. Everyday scenes such as streets, beaches and roads scored $p_h \approx 0.01$. The question was worded to catch faint smoke ("a grey or black cloud")

TABLE V
STUDY R: V3.6 OFFLINE CHECK UNDER CAMERA DEGRADATIONS (T2 SUBSET). SEVERITY M = MODERATE, S = SEVERE.

Degradation	Sev.	False appr.	Fire missed	Correct appr.	Gate rej.
None (clean)	–	0/192	0/27	107/108	0
Sensor noise	M	0/192	0/27	107/108	0
Sensor noise	S	0/192	0/27	107/108	0
Motion blur	M	0/192	0/27	106/108	0
Motion blur	S	0/192	0/27	101/108	0
Defocus	M	0/192	0/27	108/108	0
Defocus	S	0/192	0/27	108/108	0
Under-exposure	M	0/192	0/27	107/108	0
Under-exposure	S	0/192	0/27	106/108	0
Over-exposure	M	0/192	0/27	96/108	4
Over-exposure	S	0/192	0/27	59/108	24
JPEG	M	0/192	0/27	108/108	0
JPEG	S	0/192	0/27	107/108	0

and thresholded at 0.05, so it errs strongly toward stopping on real images. This is the safe direction, but outdoors it would cost much of the availability. A site-specific threshold calibration on local fire-free images is therefore a deployment prerequisite. We registered it as a follow-up study. Study P2 tested this procedure. It chose the wording and τ_h on 400 separate calibration photographs (recall ≥ 0.95 first, then the lower false-alarm rate) and applied that choice to 400 test photographs not used in calibration. The chosen wording was **TBD** with $\tau_h =$ **TBD**. On the test photographs it flagged **TBD** of those with fire or smoke (**TBD**) and **TBD** of the fire-free ones (**TBD**). For comparison, the frozen $\tau_h = 0.05$ flagged **TBD** and **TBD**, respectively. The registered claim (test recall ≥ 0.90 and test false-alarm rate ≤ 0.20) was **TBD**.

E. Cross-mission memory (campaign H)

Campaign H has 16 sequences of three missions to the same shelter. Lighting and prop placement are re-drawn each mission, and four scripted stories change the world between missions:

- the supplies are swapped and stay swapped (*relocation persists*);
- they are swapped back (*relocation changes*);
- a small fire appears and persists;
- a fire disappears and a new one appears.

The first mission seeds all three arms. Missions 2 and 3 run with no memory (M0, v3.6), naive memory (M1) and verified memory (M2). Table VI summarises the **TBD** paired missions. On the **TBD** missions whose supplies stayed relocated, M2 went straight to the right station. Its median mission time was **TBD** s against **TBD** s for M0 (exact Wilcoxon $p =$ **TBD**). M1 made **TBD** unsafe deliveries, against **TBD** for M2 (exact McNemar $p =$ **TBD**) and **TBD** for M0; Table VI gives the times of all arms. Staleness predicts two failure types for naive memory: delivering a supply that has been moved away, and delivering where a fire has appeared since the last visit; the per-trial ledger records which occurred. False refusals, that is stops at a station whose fire was already out, were **TBD** for M0, **TBD** for M1 and **TBD** for M2. The registered headline claim, verified memory keeping memory's speed-up without

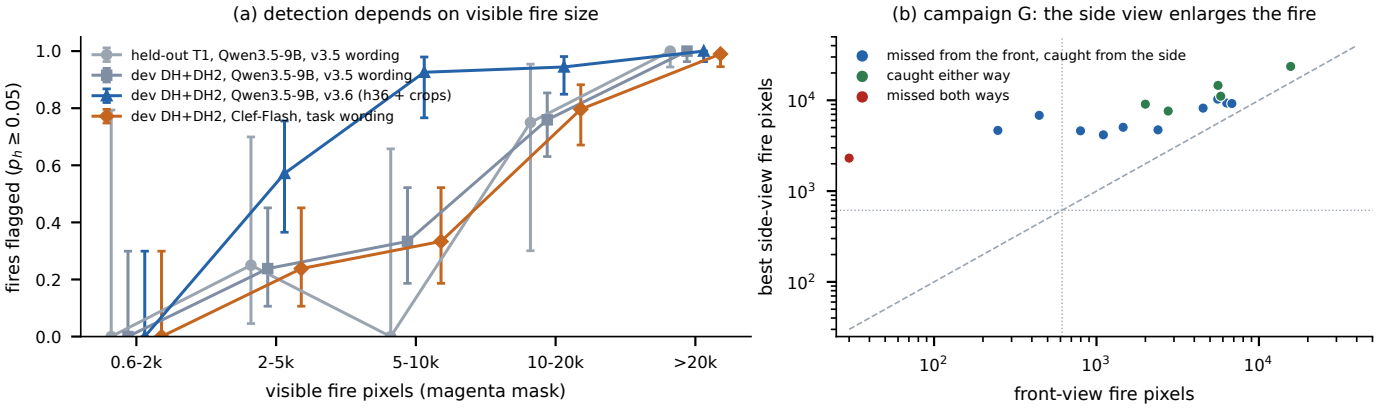


Fig. 4. (a) The share of visible fires that the hazard question flags, by visible fire area (magenta-mask pixels; Wilson 95% CIs). Fires under 2 000 pixels are missed by every configuration. The v3.6 wording with crops lifts the 2 000–10 000-pixel range. (b) Campaign G: front-view versus best side-view fire pixels for the 16 perceivable fires. Looking from the side moves the fires into the range the model detects. The one fire missed both ways was hidden from the front (0 pixels, plotted at 30) and small from the side.



Fig. 5. Study R: one held-out frame with a visible fire under the six registered degradations (severe level; the moderate level is milder). Over-exposure washes out the flames in this example. Frames that the acquisition gate rejects count as refusals.

TABLE VI
CAMPAIGN H, MISSIONS 2–3 (PAIRED). UNSAFE = WRONG SUPPLY OR A PERCEIVABLE FIRE AT THE DELIVERING STATION.

TBD

its safety cost, is **TBD**. Fig. 7 extends the campaign with a pre-registered model of repeated missions. At a change probability of $q =$ **TBD** per mission, it predicts **TBD** unsafe deliveries per 100 missions for naive memory, against **TBD** for verified memory and **TBD** without memory. The mean mission times are **TBD**, **TBD** and **TBD** s.

F. Two AIs on one GPU (campaign J)

The second model is only as good as the question it is asked. Asked the original Jev request, which concerns whether a *passage* is safe, Clef-Flash approved half the correct deliveries on development data. Asked the task-worded question, it approved 97%. On the held-out T2 set, Clef-Flash with task wording alone made 0/407 false approvals (187/193 correct). Together with Qwen3.5-4B, the pair that fits on one 32 GB V100, it made 0/407 (185/193 correct). Campaign J ran this pair on the robot, paired with v3.6 on 24 worlds that include swapped, empty and small-fire stations. The two-model configuration (Qwen3.5-4B plus Clef-Flash) behaved as expected in **TBD** runs (v3.6: **TBD**, exact McNemar $p =$ **TBD**), with **TBD** unsafe deliveries (v3.6: **TBD**) and **TBD** stack failures. Peak GPU memory was **TBD** GB, and the median check latency was **TBD** s for the two-model system and **TBD** s for v3.6. The registered claim that the original two-model design runs on the simulated robot with no extra risk is **TBD**.

G. Instruction parsing

On the 60 held-out utterances the hybrid parser was correct for 55/60 with 0 unsafe acceptances. The previous TF-IDF parser was correct for 31 with 2 unsafe acceptances. The five errors were all refusals of valid requests, so they fail closed.

VI. DISCUSSION

When should a robot trust its memory? The naive policy is not a straw man: skipping a check that succeeded a few minutes ago is exactly what an efficiency-minded system would do. Campaign H and the change-rate model test how dangerous this is at a disaster site. Its risk should grow with how often the world changes, which the robot cannot observe without looking (registered headline claim: **TBD**). Observation 1 and Corollary 1 give a rule that makes the question moot for safety. Memory may decide the order and the strictness of the checks, never their existence. What memory may then buy is time in

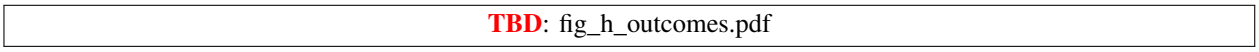


Fig. 6. Campaign H, missions 2 and 3 of the 16 sequences. (a) Outcome of each mission under no memory (M0), naive memory (M1) and verified memory (M2); rows are sequences, grouped by scripted story (S1–S4). A failed mission is hatched. (b) Mission time of the missions whose relocation persisted, for each arm; lines join the M0 and M2 times of the same mission, bars mark medians.

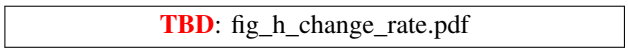


Fig. 7. Model of repeated missions with the per-check rates measured in G and H ($p_{\mathrm{det}} =$ **TBD**, $n =$ **TBD**): unsafe deliveries and mean mission time of the three memory policies as the world changes more often. The curves are computed from measured per-check rates, so their order is a model prediction, not an observation.

persistent worlds, at the price of a detour when the world changes back.

Moving beats thinking harder. The largest single safety gain in our tests came from moving 0.4 m (G), not from a larger model, a better prompt or a second model. (T2, whose fires were easy, left no false approvals to remove, so it cannot rank models on safety.) A fire hidden behind a box carries no pixels to reason about.

What pre-registration bought us. Beyond the outcomes of H, J and R above, three registered claims failed or were not significant:

- false approvals below 2% on T1;
- a benefit of better wording and crops in closed loop (F);
- any measurable change on T2, whose fires happened to be easy (a power failure: no false approvals were left to remove).

Each failure redirected the work: it exposed the hidden-fire weakness and led to the look-around. Without registration, each could have been rationalised away.

Cost of verification. A check takes about 5.5 s and the look-around about 32 s, against about 39 s of driving between station and shelter (Supp. Table S1). For relief logistics, where a wrong delivery costs a round trip and a delivery into a fire costs far more, this trade is favourable. Memory recovers part of it when the world is persistent.

VII. Limitations

All results are from simulation. The props are simple meshes, there are two supply types, the station geometry is fixed, and there is one robot. The VLM sees rendered images. Study R covers sensor degradations, but not the appearance gap of real objects, real smoke or clutter. Our "hazard" is a stylised fire. Campaign H scripts its changes, and the change-rate model assumes independent changes. The memory has a fixed horizon of three missions and two stations, so a richer site would need a spatial memory such as a scene graph. Corollary 1 assumes a per-check false-approval bound that holds uniformly over the stations a route meets. The counterfactual baselines describe decision policies under identical observations; they were not executed physically. Fire labels come from pixel counts. Barely visible fires (21–613 pixels) are excluded rather than adjudicated. The guard is hand-written, not formally synthesised [32], [33]. The next step is a real platform with real supplies.

VIII. Conclusion

In our simulation experiments, a local VLM served as a pre-action gate for relief-supply delivery with few false approvals (T1: 5 of 408 for v3.4 and 3 for v3.5, although the registered 2% bound was not met) when its role was limited to scored multiple-choice verification, motion was kept behind an independent guard and the robot looked again from the side. Whether the gate stays fail-closed under camera degradation (R: supported), whether safety-monotone memory keeps its speed-up without a safety cost (H: **TBD**) and whether the two-model design runs without extra risk (J: **TBD**) are registered claims reported in Sec. V. Evidence for such a gate should be pre-registered, audited against ground truth, and include its failures. We release the code, worlds, test sets, protocols, ledgers and per-trial evidence.

Reproducibility

One Dockerfile builds the full stack: ROS 2 Jazzy, Gazebo Harmonic, PyTorch, transformers. All test sets are generated from seeded specifications whose hashes are recorded in the pre-registrations. All campaigns, including the aborted ones, are in `experiments/results`. Every number in this paper is produced by `scripts/paper_numbers.py` from those files.

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